

United States History and Geography — Teacher Key

United States History and Geography · Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28 · Form US-CORE-D

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classroom-formative · pre-field-test. Item parameters are estimates and have not met a student; this form is not a calibrated instrument. This is a selected-response form. It assesses Depth of Knowledge levels 1 through 3. It carries no extended-response item, so it does not assess DOK-4 — a four-option question cannot ask a student to construct and defend an argument. Extended responses and document-based questions are delivered as separate activities.

1. How did FDR's court-packing plan affect the political climate surrounding the New Deal?
- A. It immediately caused the Supreme Court to reverse all rulings against New Deal programs
 - B. It unified Democrats and Republicans in support of a bipartisan expansion of New Deal programs
 - C. It had no significant political effect because Congress quickly approved the plan within weeks
 - D. It galvanized opposition from both parties and undermined public support for FDR's broader agenda

KEY: D · DOK 2 · US.46

Why the key is right: The court-packing scheme backfired politically: it was seen as an assault on the separation of powers, alienated conservative Democrats, energized Republican opposition, and weakened the New Deal coalition — even as the Supreme Court simultaneously began to uphold New Deal legislation.

Item analysis

Standard

US.46 — Analyze the effects of and the controversies arising from New Deal economic policies, including charges of socialism and President Franklin D. Roosevelt's "court packing" attempt.

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 1.3 · b 0.7 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

classroom-formative (tcapFormat: false — not affirmed — no human has judged this item field-testable)

Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

no misconception named — a distractor written to be merely wrong is noise, not diagnosis

2. In 1937, when the Supreme Court struck down several key New Deal programs as unconstitutional, FDR proposed his 'court-packing' plan to add up to six new justices. The plan was ultimately rejected — even by many congressional Democrats. Which analysis BEST explains why even FDR's political allies opposed the court-packing plan?

- A. Even New Deal supporters recognized that manipulating court composition to ensure favorable rulings would undermine judicial independence as a structural protection for all future governments — a precedent they were unwilling to set regardless of their policy preferences.
- B. Democrats opposed the plan because they feared that adding justices would increase the federal judiciary's workload, requiring additional funding that would undermine New Deal spending priorities.
- C. Congressional Democrats opposed the plan because they believed the Supreme Court's rulings against New Deal programs were correct on constitutional grounds, and that FDR should instead write legislation that complied with the Constitution.
- D. Democrats in Congress opposed court-packing because FDR had not consulted them before announcing the plan, and the lack of consultation was seen as an executive overreach that threatened the independence of the legislative branch.

KEY: A · DOK 3 · US.46

Why the key is right: Even Democrats who supported New Deal policies opposed court-packing because manipulating the Supreme Court's composition to guarantee favorable rulings would destroy its independence as a co-equal branch of government. If FDR could pack the court when he disliked its rulings, a future conservative president could do the same. The principle of judicial independence is a structural protection for everyone — regardless of their policy preferences. FDR's allies understood that undermining the separation of powers to achieve short-term policy goals would set a precedent that threatened the constitutional order itself. This requires students to reason about institutional principles beyond partisan preferences.

Item analysis

Standard

US.46 — Analyze the effects of and the controversies arising from New Deal economic policies, including charges of socialism and President Franklin D. Roosevelt's "court packing" attempt.

DOK / Hess

Level 3 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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IRT

a 1.41 · b 1.06 · c 0.22 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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3. Summarize the main ways the United States responded to post-WWII global challenges between 1945-1950.

- A. As president, he had authority to commit U.S. resources and set foreign policy direction
- B. Created the UN, provided Marshall Plan aid, formed NATO alliance, and intervened in Korea
- C. Economic stability would make nations less vulnerable to communist pressure and influence
- D. It committed the U.S. to actively intervening globally to support threatened free nations

KEY: B · DOK 2 · US.58, US.60, US.63

Why the key is right: Created the UN, provided Marshall Plan aid, formed NATO alliance, and intervened in Korea. The United States sent billions of dollars to rebuild Western Europe and strengthen it against communist influence. D is incorrect because it describes a different program, event, or idea than this Cold War development. It shaped the early Cold War and the postwar order the United States helped build after 1945.

Item analysis

Standard

US.58 — Identify and explain the reasons for the founding of the United Nations, including the role of Cordell Hull.

Standard

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

Standard

US.63 — Analyze the causes and effects of the Second Red Scare, including Americans' attitudes toward McCarthyism, blacklisting, House Un-American Activities Committee (i.e., HUAC), and Julius and Ethel Rosenberg.

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 1.26 · b 1.52 · c 0.22 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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4. The Truman Doctrine (1947) pledged American support for free peoples resisting subjugation, while the Marshall Plan (1947) committed roughly \$13 billion to European economic reconstruction. How do these two initiatives together reflect a coherent and unified strategic logic for containing Soviet influence in postwar Europe?

A. The Truman Doctrine and Marshall Plan were complementary primarily through their combined military and security dimensions — both relied on American military guarantees to deter Soviet armed aggression, with economic aid functioning as a secondary incentive to maintain Western-aligned governments.

B. The Truman Doctrine established a global ideological framework for containment, but the Marshall Plan was primarily motivated by American economic self-interest in creating prosperous European export markets — suggesting that strategic and commercial interests happened to align in this case rather than reflecting a single coherent anti-Soviet vision.

C. The two initiatives reflected the strategic insight that communism thrived in conditions of economic desperation and political instability — military containment alone would be insufficient if poverty created conditions in which Soviet-backed political movements could gain genuine popular support, making economic reconstruction a strategic necessity rather than purely humanitarian charity.

D. Truman and Marshall designed their respective programs as deliberate provocations intended to force the Soviet Union into an unsustainable military competition, representing early applications of the rollback strategy later associated with Eisenhower's New Look defense policy.

KEY: C · DOK 3 · US.60

Why the key is right: The Truman Doctrine and Marshall Plan embodied the strategic insight that communism was not primarily a military threat in postwar Western Europe but a political one — vulnerable populations under economic stress might turn to communist parties offering material solutions, making economic stabilization a direct instrument of political containment.

Item analysis

Standard

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

DOK / Hess

Level 3 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

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a 1.2 · b 1.0 · c 0.25 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

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Historian review

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Distractor diagnosis

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5. What was interposition as a response to Brown v. Board?

- A. It ordered desegregation to proceed with "all deliberate speed"
- B. They closed public schools for five years rather than integrate
- C. Southern states' policy of defying Brown through school closures
- D. A theory that states could nullify federal rulings they opposed

KEY: D · DOK 1 · US.74

Why the key is right: Interposition was the segregationist theory that a state could block or nullify a federal court ruling it opposed. Choices about cooperation with Brown are wrong because interposition was designed to resist desegregation. The idea failed legally, but it reveals how far Southern officials stretched states' rights arguments.

Item analysis

Standard

US.74 — Examine the decision and impacts of Brown v. Board of Education on the desegregation of schools, such as Scarboro 85, Clinton 12 and Little Rock 9. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 1 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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IRT

a 0.95 · b 1.14 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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6. How did Brown v. Board of Education affect the broader civil rights movement in the United States?

A. It demonstrated that legal strategies could successfully challenge racial inequality and inspired activists to pursue further civil rights litigation and legislation

B. It shifted the civil rights movement away from legal strategies toward direct political action as the only effective approach

C. It caused Congress to pass the Civil Rights Act within a year of the ruling, ending decades of segregation

D. It immediately ended all forms of legal segregation by striking down Jim Crow laws across every sector of public life

KEY: A · DOK 2 · US.74

Why the key is right: Brown validated the NAACP's legal strategy and gave civil rights activists a landmark precedent to build upon. It energized the movement by proving that the federal judiciary could be an instrument of racial justice.

Item analysis

Standard

US.74 — Examine the decision and impacts of Brown v. Board of Education on the desegregation of schools, such as Scarboro 85, Clinton 12 and Little Rock 9. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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Historian review

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Distractor diagnosis

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7. What was Strom Thurmond's stance on civil rights legislation?

- A. He publicly supported it as a moderate bipartisan Southern Democrat
- B. He fiercely opposed it and conducted a record 24-hour filibuster
- C. He drafted and proposed compromise versions of civil rights bills
- D. He strategically abstained from voting on all civil rights measures

KEY: B · DOK 1 · US.76

Why the key is right: Strom Thurmond fiercely opposed civil rights legislation and became famous for his 24-hour filibuster against an earlier civil rights bill. Choices describing him as a civil rights supporter are wrong because he was one of the movement's most visible Senate opponents. His resistance showed how deeply segregation was defended in national politics.

Item analysis

Standard

US.76 — Examine the roles and actions of civil rights advocates (e.g., Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., Malcolm X, John Lewis, Diane Nash, Thurgood Marshall, Rosa Parks) and opponents (e.g., Bull Connor, Orval Faubus, George Wallace, Strom Thurmond). (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 1 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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a 0.92 · b 0.26 · c 0.22 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

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Bias / sensitivity

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Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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8. How did Bull Connor's response to civil rights demonstrations in Birmingham, Alabama in 1963 affect the national civil rights movement?

- A. Connor's actions in Birmingham caused the civil rights movement to abandon nonviolent tactics and adopt more confrontational methods
- B. Connor's policing of Birmingham demonstrations prompted Southern moderates to join the civil rights movement in large numbers
- C. Connor's use of fire hoses and police dogs against peaceful demonstrators was televised nationally, generating public outrage that increased pressure on the Kennedy administration to act on civil rights
- D. Connor's restrained policing of demonstrations in Birmingham helped maintain order and prevented the movement from gaining national attention

KEY: C · DOK 2 · US.76

Why the key is right: Connor's televised brutality against peaceful marchers, including children, galvanized national and international opinion. Kennedy cited the Birmingham demonstrations as a turning point in his decision to introduce comprehensive civil rights legislation.

Item analysis

Standard

US.76 — Examine the roles and actions of civil rights advocates (e.g., Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., Malcolm X, John Lewis, Diane Nash, Thurgood Marshall, Rosa Parks) and opponents (e.g., Bull Connor, Orval Faubus, George Wallace, Strom Thurmond). (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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9. Why was the Voting Rights Act of 1965 considered necessary even after the Civil Rights Act of 1964 had already been passed?

- A. The Voting Rights Act was necessary because the 1964 Act had accidentally removed protections for African American voters that had existed under the Fifteenth Amendment
- B. Congress passed the Voting Rights Act to satisfy demands from Northern Democrats who felt the 1964 Act had been too focused on Southern voting rights
- C. The Civil Rights Act of 1964 had been struck down by the Supreme Court before it could take effect, making new legislation necessary
- D. The Civil Rights Act did not directly address voting rights, and Southern states continued using literacy tests, poll taxes, and intimidation to prevent African Americans from voting

KEY: D · DOK 2 · US.78

Why the key is right: After 1964, African Americans in many Southern counties still could not vote due to literacy tests, economic threats, and violence. The Selma to Montgomery marches (Bloody Sunday) demonstrated this gap and prompted LBJ to push for the Voting Rights Act.

Item analysis

Standard

US.78 — Analyze civil and voting rights legislation, including the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, the Civil Rights Act of 1968 (i.e., Fair Housing Act), and the 24th Amendment. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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10. The Civil Rights Act of 1964 prohibited racial discrimination in public accommodations, employment, and federally funded programs. Given that many Southern states had maintained legally enforced segregation for nearly a century after the Fourteenth Amendment's passage, what does the Act's eventual passage most reveal about the conditions required for transformative civil rights legislation?

A. The Act's passage required the convergence of sustained grassroots mobilization that disrupted segregation's daily functioning, television coverage that made white violence against nonviolent protesters politically costly to tolerate, and presidential leadership committed to legislative action — demonstrating that transformative civil rights legislation emerges from the alignment of movement pressure, public opinion shifts, and executive political

B. The Act's passage shows that economic modernization in the South had eroded the material foundation of segregation by creating a business class that recognized international competitiveness required abandoning racial discrimination, making economic development the primary structural driver of civil rights legislation.

C. The Act demonstrated that moral argument alone can overcome entrenched racial hierarchies, as the movement's nonviolent discipline and the moral clarity of its witness ultimately convinced a sufficient congressional majority to act despite fierce Southern opposition.

D. The Civil Rights Act passed primarily because of Lyndon Johnson's legislative mastery and his exploitation of the national emotional response to Kennedy's assassination, suggesting that individual political leadership and historically contingent events were more decisive than structural conditions in producing the legislation.

KEY: A · DOK 3 · US.78

Why the key is right: The Civil Rights Act required multiple conditions aligned simultaneously: the civil rights movement had disrupted segregation's stability; television had transformed local white violence into national political liabilities; Cold War ideology made racial discrimination internationally embarrassing; and Johnson provided the executive commitment and legislative strategy to convert movement pressure into law.

Item analysis

Standard

US.78 — Analyze civil and voting rights legislation, including the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, the Civil Rights Act of 1968 (i.e., Fair Housing Act), and the 24th Amendment.
(T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

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